

CEREMONIAL OF THE FREE GARDENERS

I., II. and III. Degree, together with catechisms, customs and history



Glory to the Supreme Gardener of the Universe

Then the LORD God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to tend and keep it.
(Genesis 2:15)



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Notes Before the Meeting Starts

Gatekeeper (GK): No sign is given when entering the lodge.

Gatekeeper (GK): Before the Collection of Funds at the end of the meeting, please remember to include the members outside the lodge room so everyone has a chance to contribute.

Worthy Master (WM): If needed, review the degree signs, tokens, word mottos, voting sign, and speaking sign. Also, remind the lodge that apprentices are not permitted to speak during meetings. *[this review is only given to verified members of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners]*

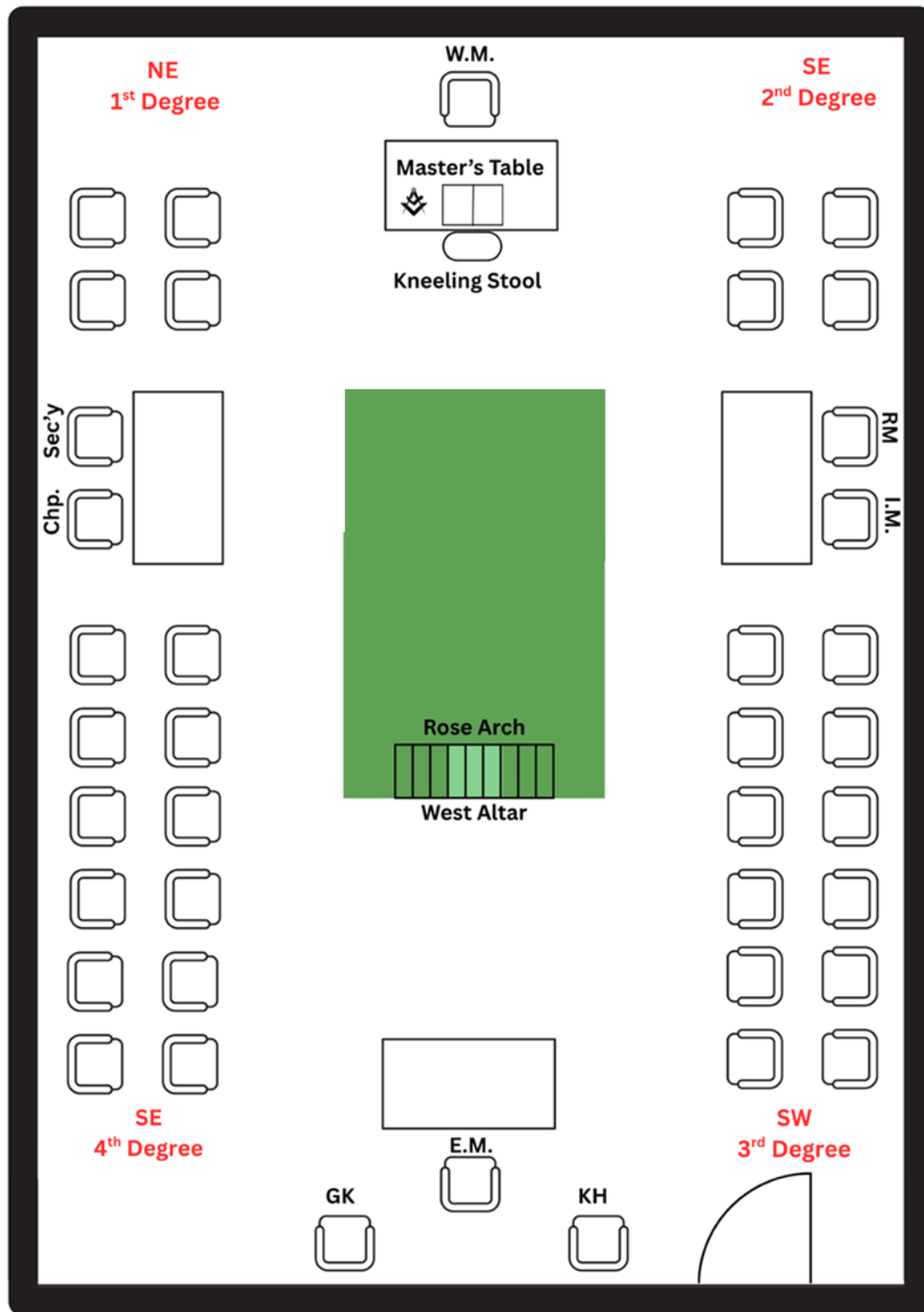
Gatekeeper (GK): Blindfold candidates at the gate, one at a time if multiple candidates are to be admitted *[unless they are to be admitted as a group]*.

If there are multiple candidates being admitted on the same night, ensure that a sheet or paper is placed on the Bible for each seeker, for sanitary reasons, and that there are enough seats for the candidates *[in the designate section highlighted in the ceremony]*.

Free Gardner Symbols

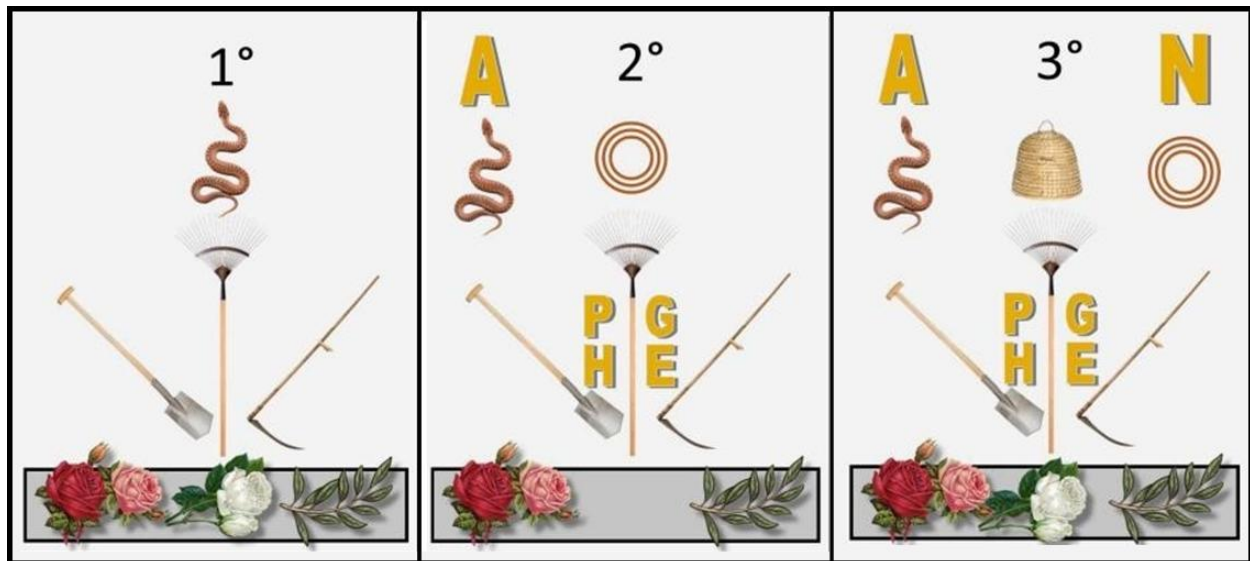
	← Apprentice Lodge Apprentice →	
	← Journeyman Lodge Journeyman →	
	← Master Lodge Master →	
	← Past Master Lodge Past Master →	

§1 Lodge Diagram and Tools



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The following ceremony represents the official standard and must be observed precisely. No alterations to its wording or format are allowed, and no additional ceremonies or ritual acts may be introduced.



On the West Altar—the sole altar used in Free Gardener ceremonies—there are three roses and a horizontally placed olive branch. From left to right, the roses are white, red, and pink. Above the altar stands a simple, undecorated rose arch (see lodge diagram).

For a lodge opened in the First Degree, the carpet should feature:

- A rake in the center, with its tines pointing upward toward the east,
- A spade to the right of the rake,
- A scythe to the left of the rake,
- And a snake positioned above the rake.

(Refer to diagram.)

In a lodge opened in the Second Degree, the carpet includes:

- The rake, spade, and scythe in the same positions as before,
- The letter “A” in the top right corner,
- A snake directly below the “A,”
- The Three Concentric Circles above the rake,
- The letters “P” and “H” placed vertically to the right of the rake,
- And the letters “G” and “E” also placed vertically to the right of the rake.

(Refer to diagram.)

For a lodge opened in the Third Degree, all elements from the second degree remain in place. In addition, the carpet includes:

- The letter “N” in the top left corner,
 - A beehive centered above the rake, with its entrance facing west,
 - And the Three Concentric Circles now centered beneath the letter “N.”
- (Refer to diagram.)

Master’s Table:

The letter “S” is placed on the kneeling stool in front of the Master’s table. In the Third Degree only, the letter “S” is instead placed on the Chaplain’s table before the lodge opens, and the kneeling stool then bears the letter “O.”

The general arrangement in the Mother Lodge includes a square placed above a compass, with a pruning knife—opened to a 90° angle—positioned above the compass. The blade of the knife faces to the left.

Seating Arrangement:

There are no assigned seats along the North and South sides of the lodge. However, sufficient seating must be provided for all candidates during degree ceremonies.

- **Apprentices** sit in the northeast during their degree,
- **Journeymen** in the southeast,
- **Masters** in the southwest.

Customs within the degree work specify the following seating arrangements:

- Apprentices may sit only in the northeast,
- Journeymen may sit in both the northeast and southeast,
- Masters may sit in the northeast, southeast, and southwest,
- Past-Masters may sit in the northeast, southeast, southwest, and northwest.

§2 Explanation of the Necessary Signs

General Sign (Apprentice Sign):

The general sign is the same as the apprentice sign. The apprentice sign consists of ----- the ----- the ----- and after a short time dropping the arm down to --- ----- . The ----- is placed parallel to the fingers.

While moving about the lodge, the general sign—(same as above)—is maintained until the task is completed. Only then should the arm be lowered to --- -----.

Speaking Sign:

The ----- is held -- - ----- from the ---- and the ----- -- ----- with --- ----- . To request the floor during a meeting you will stand and give the sign.

The member keeps this position while speaking, until finished and acknowledged by the Worthy Master. Before sitting down, the arm is lowered to --- -----.

Voting Sign:

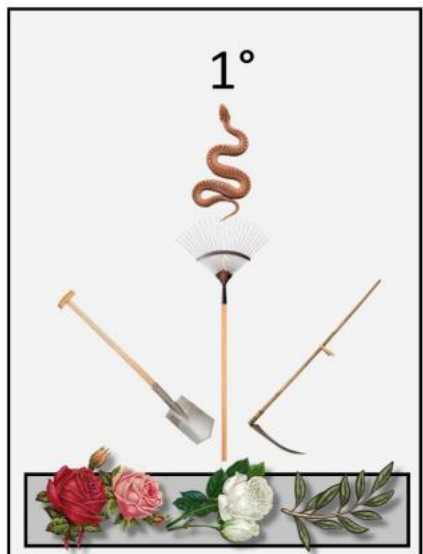
To cast a vote during lodge meetings, the ---- --- is held -- - ----- from the ---- and the ----- -- ----- with --- ----- .

Hold the position until the Worthy Master has surveyed the room and signals for the sign to be lowered.

Sign of Reverence (prayer):

The sign of reverence is given when we pray in the lodge and is performed as follows: The ---- and ----- are brought -- ----- of the ----. The ----- of the ---- are ----- with --- ----- . The ----- of the ----- are ----- the ----.

§3 Free Gardener-Apprentice: Opening



Members may enter the garden [lodge] once the Gatekeeper has opened the gate and extended an invitation. As they file in, the Worthy Master (WM) and the Keepers remain standing but do not give the general sign.

Silence is observed while members take their seats. Background music may play during this time and continue until the gate is closed. After a knock is heard at the door, private conversations should cease entirely.

Anyone wishing to speak during the meeting must notify the Secretary in advance, who will relay their request to the Worthy Master.

All Keepers and the WM take their seats before the lodge is officially opened. Once everyone is seated and silence falls over the room, the Worthy Master gives three raps on the table with his Pruning Knife. These are echoed by the Emissary Master (EM) with his own.

WM: ● ● ●

EM: ● ● ●

The WM addresses the lodge:

WM: Welcome, beloved brothers and sisters. Please rise.

All rise and give the Apprentice Sign.

WM: Emissary Master, what is our first duty?

EM: To confirm that the Keyholder is at his post and in possession of the key to the garden, Worthy Master.

The Keyholder raises the key for the Worthy Master to see. The Worthy Master acknowledges with a nod then turns back to the Emissary Master.

WM: Emissary Master, what is our next duty?

EM: To confirm that all present are Free Gardeners, Worthy Master.

WM: Emissary Master, perform your duty.

The Emissary Master turns to address the lodge.

EM: Brothers and sisters, give me the Apprentice Sign.

All present give the Apprentice Sign toward the Emissary Master, except the Emissary Master himself and the Worthy Master.

The Emissary Master turns back to the Worthy Master.

EM: Worthy Master, I can vouch for all who are present.

He then gives the Apprentice Sign in the direction of the Worthy Master, who is not required to return it.

WM: Let us unite in prayer before opening the lodge.

All members give and hold the Sign of Reverence until the prayer concludes [second amen].

Chaplain: Supreme Gardener, Father of all Gardeners, who manifests His infinite majesty, power, and goodness among us here on earth. We thank You for having planted the fruits of humanity in a garden long ago and having placed us among Your wondrous creations. Amen.

All: Amen.

WM: Worthy Keepers, brothers and sisters, we gather here today in agreement with the customs of the Apprentice Degree. I ask for your patience and undivided attention during. Remain centered and undistracted by the world's temptations and committed to the common good. May our assembly be guided by order, peace, and harmony.

May each of us conduct ourselves with tranquility, honesty, fairness, and confidence as we carry out our duties.

The Chaplain proceeds to the Master's Table and opens the Bible to Genesis 2:8. To his left, as seen from his position, the compass, square, and pruning knife are arranged on the Master's table. The WM waits until the chaplain has returned to his seat:

WM: In the name of the Supreme Gardener of the Universe, I declare this Apprentice Lodge officially open.

EM: So be it done!

WM: Brothers and sisters, you may now be seated.

The Worthy Master proceeds to ask the following questions if there are admissions. Otherwise, the approved AOFG Lodge Agenda is used.

WM: Brother Secretary, have any apologies [for absence] or other communications been received?

Secretary: [Replies: Worthy Master, ...]

WM: Brother Secretary, has any member recently done something that deserves recognition—either for their contribution to our lodge or the Order as a whole?

Secretary: [Replies: Worthy Master, ...]

WM: Brother Secretary, does any member wish to present a suggestion, proposal, or recommendation?

Secretary: [Replies: Worthy Master, ...]

WM: Brother Secretary, have any seekers been recommended for the Apprentice Degree?

Secretary: [Replies: Worthy Master, ...]

If the Secretary responds in the affirmative, the Gatekeeper quietly retires—without prompting—to prepare the first seeker(s).

§4 Free Gardener-Apprentice: Admission

The Gatekeeper signals the Keyholder by making noises that a seeker is standing in front of the gate. Keyholder:

Keyholder: Worthy Master, there are noises at the gate.

Worthy Master: Brother Keyholder, see who is there.

The Keyholder opens the gate and addresses the Gatekeeper.

Keyholder: Who goes there?

Gatekeeper: It is Mr./Mrs. [First and Last Name], who seeks instruction in gardening, metaphorical gardening, and the mysteries of horticulture. They have heard that such knowledge can be found here.

The Keyholder closes the door, holds up the key and says:

Keyholder: Worthy Master, it is our Gatekeeper with Mr./Mrs. [First and Last Name], who seeks instruction in gardening, metaphorical gardening, and the mysteries of horticulture. They believe have heard that such knowledge can be found here.

WM: Then let us help him/her gain this knowledge.

WM: Instruction Master, perform the duty of your office and confirm whether he/she is worthy of Admission.

The Instruction Master goes to the gate, the Keyholder opens the gate for him, and then lets the blindfolded seeker enter under the guidance of the Gatekeeper, who leads him by the right hand. - The Keyholder quietly closes the gate behind them both.

§5 Free Gardener-Apprentice: General Obligations

The Gatekeeper continues to hold the seeker's hand while the Instruction Master steps in front of the seeker and speaks to him:

Instruction Master: Seeker, I have been informed that you wish to become a Free Gardener. Before you proceed, you must know that we uphold our own customs, rules, duties, and regulations—rooted in justice, philanthropy, and care.

All Free Gardeners before you have accepted these with joy and have pledged, with a solemn vow, to treat one another with courtesy and to never reveal—by sign, word, or action—the secrets of our Order.

As they have bound themselves to us through these same obligations, we ask the same of you.

Will you uphold our customs, rules, duties, and regulations?
If so, respond: **I will.**

Seeker: I will.

The Instruction Master stands to the left of the seeker. With his right hand, he gently takes hold of the seeker's right upper arm from behind. With his left hand, he grasps the seeker's left hand. The Keyholder and the Gatekeeper then return to their seats near the gate. The Gatekeeper remains inside the lodge for the rest of the ceremony—unless multiple Admissions are taking place, in which case he retires from the lodge before the next seeker enters.

§6 Free Gardener-Apprentice: The Fourfold Journey

WM: All rise!

The Instruction Master conducts the Seeker to the west of the Garden and stands before the EM, facing east toward the WM. The Instruction Master gives the Seeker's answers to the EM's questions as needed.

EM: Seeker, what flower sprouts in spring, and resembles a yellow trumpet?

Seeker [with the assistance of the Instruction Master]: The daffodil (Narcissus).

Secretary: The golden yellow color of the Narcissus (nar-SIS-sus), commonly known as the Daffodil, represents faith, but also the sun itself. By using this color for letters, signs, symbols, hems, braids, and fringes of the Free Gardener's regalia, it serves as a symbol of the ennoblement of one's character.

The Instruction Master and the seeker go to the north. They remain standing, facing the south.

EM: Seeker, what flower covers the forest floor, like a blue sea?

Seeker [with the assistance of the Instruction Master]: The bluebell (Mertensia).

Secretary: The deep blue color of the Mertensia (mur-TEN-see-uh), commonly known as the Bluebell, is considered a symbol of divinity and fidelity, as well as of the sky and water. It is the most common color for the aprons and sashes of the Free Gardeners, because fidelity is the basis of our brotherhood.

In the manner described above, the Instruction Master conducts the Seeker from the north to the east and halts in front of the WM, facing west toward the EM.

EM: Seeker, on which mighty tree does the acorn grow?

Seeker [with the assistance of the Instruction Master]: On the oak tree (Quercus).

Secretary: The mighty trunk of the Quercus (KWEAR-cus), commonly known as the Oak, stands for Endurance. The green color of the tree crown stands for hope and abundance. Endurance, Hope, and olive are the most ardent supporters of the free gardener.

The Instruction Master conducts the seeker from the east to the south and stops there, facing the north.

EM: Seeker, which flower gives off a sweet fragrance, has the softest petals and is adorned with thorns on the stem?

Seeker [with the assistance of the Instruction Master]: The rose (Rosa).

Secretary: The pure white color of the Rosa (ROW-suh), commonly known as the Rose, expresses the innocence and purity of metaphorical gardening, which is characterized by the constant labor and moral training of the Free Gardener. The blood-red color of the rose expresses love, which, along with faith and hope, is the greatest among them (Corinthians 13:13). The pink rose expresses the life of creativity that comes from the intimate communion of purity and love.

The WM addresses the lodge:

WM: My brothers and sisters, you may be seated.

*If only one Seeker is being admitted, the Instruction Master guides them from the south to the west as previously described, stopping there [west] to face the Worthy Master. If there are multiple Seekers, the current Seeker is seated in the northeast of the lodge, and the next is introduced in the same way. *For a larger group, this section may be conducted collectively, with each Seeker responding individually.*

If all the Seekers to be admitted are seated in the northeast, the Instruction Master instructs them to stand together. They join hands, with the Instruction Master holding the hand of the first Seeker, forming a continuous line. Together, they proceed in front of the West Altar and face the Worthy Master

Each Seeker will respond individually to the following questions. In the case of multiple admissions, begin with the Seeker closest to the Instruction Master.

§7 Free Gardener-Apprentice: The Three Principles

WM: Mr./Mrs. [First and Last Name], your answers so far have proven that you possess some knowledge of operative gardening and demonstrated your attentiveness as a seeker. It will take many years, but our Order will teach you much more about operative gardening, metaphorical gardening and the mysteries of horticulture.

Is it still your desire to be admitted, and to be solemnly bound to our customs, rules, and duties?

Seeker [with the assistance of the Instruction Master]: It is.

The Instruction Master then turns the Seeker to face the Examining Master. If there are multiple Seekers, each is turned toward the Examining Master individually after responding "It is."

Instruction Master: I present to you a Seeker who desires to share in the fruits of metaphorical gardening and embrace its guiding principles.

EM: Seeker, you have entered the sanctuary of our garden of your own free will. It is here that the path of cultivation begins—not with soil alone, but with spirit and understanding.

Now, I shall draw your attention to three sacred principles that every Free Gardener must hold in reverence.

A Free Gardener must commit to:

First: Embrace the principles of our Order with diligence, care, and attention, so that you may master their practice.

Second: Never reveal the secrets of the Order, ensuring that those who are seditious or disloyal cannot exploit or damage our benevolent institution.

Third: From this moment, you are bound to all free gardeners by an unbreakable vow of friendship. Be sincere with each of them; visit the sick, support them in times of grief and need. Be a good Samaritan—one who, with the healing balm of comfort drawn from the true principles of metaphorical gardening, eases the sorrow and suffering of all humanity on life's pilgrimage.

Are you prepared to make these principles your purpose in your life?

Seeker [with the assistance of the Instruction Master]: I am.

§8 Free Gardener-Apprentice: Sharing the Light.

The WM addresses the lodge:

WM: All rise!

The Instruction Master leads the Seeker from the south to the Master's table in the east. The letter "S" rests on the kneeling stool and is removed by the Instruction Master before the Seeker is instructed to kneel. The Seeker is then directed to kneel on both knees. After each vow, the

Instruction Master replaces the letter "S" on the kneeling stool. The Gatekeeper lowers the lights.

Chaplain: And the Lord God made a garden in the east, in Eden; and there he put the man whom he had formed (Genesis 2:8).

The Instruction Master stands behind the Seeker and removes the blindfold from the Seeker's eyes. (If there are multiple Admissions, the lights should be lowered for each Seeker individually.)

After the blindfold is removed, the Instruction Master places both hands gently on the Seeker's shoulders and says:

Instruction Master: Beware of temptation and the wiles of the evil one.

This is done individually for each Seeker if more than one is present. Shortly afterward, the Gatekeeper raises the lights.

The Instruction Master assists the Seeker in rising. After placing the letter "S" back on the kneeling stool, he prepares to lead the Seeker by the hand, as previously described.

The Worthy Master then addresses the lodge:

WM: My brothers and sisters, you may be seated.

§9 Free Gardener-Apprentice: Bible Reading (ADAM)

The Worthy Master takes his seat. The Instruction Master leads the Seeker to the western edge of the carpet, facing east toward the Worthy Master.

The Chaplain then takes the letter "A" from his table, holds it up, and addressing the Seeker says:

Chaplain: ADAM

The Chaplain then places the letter "A" on the carpet, centered above the snake (see §1). He returns to his seat and reads the designated Bible passage from a printed card or sheet, not from an actual Bible:

Chaplain: The LORD God made all kinds of trees grow out of the ground—trees that were pleasing to the eye and good for food. In the middle of the garden were the tree of life and the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. A river watering the garden flowed from Eden; from there it was separated into four headwaters (Genesis 2:9-10).

[short pause.]

The Chaplain then takes the letter "P" from his table, holds it up, and addresses the Seeker:

Chaplain: The name of the first is Pishon (PISH-awn),

The chaplain then places the letter "P" on the carpet, returns to his table and continues reading:

Chaplain: ... which goes round about all the land of Havilah (HAH-vee-lah) where there is gold, and the gold of that land is good: there is bdellium (DEL-lee-um) and the onyx stone (Genesis 2:11-12).

[Short pause.]

The Chaplain then takes the letter "G" from his table, holds it up, and addresses the Seeker:

Chaplain: And the name of the second river is Gihon (GEE-hawn), ...

The chaplain then places the letter "G" on the work carpet, returns to his table and continues reading:

Chaplain: ... this river goes round all the land of Cush (Genesis 2:13).

[Short pause.]

The chaplain then takes the letter "H" from his table, holds it up, and addresses the seeker:

Chaplain: And the name of the third river is Hiddekel (hi-DEK-el),

The chaplain then places the letter "H" on the work carpet, returns to his table and continues reading:

Chaplain: ... which goes to the east of Assyria (Genesis 2:14).

[Short pause.]

The chaplain then takes the letter "E" from his table, holds it up, and addresses the seeker:

Chaplain: And the fourth river is Euphrates (yoo-FRAY-tees). (Genesis 2:14)

The chaplain then places the letter "E" on the work carpet, then returns to his table.

[Short pause.]

Chaplain: Then the LORD God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to tend and keep it (Genesis 2:15).

After a brief pause, the chaplain takes his seat.

The EM addresses the seeker:

EM: I now commend you to our Worthy Master, who will further instruct you on the principles of our Order.

§10 Free Gardener-Apprentice: Vow

The WM addresses the lodge:

WM: All rise!

The Instruction Master conducts each Seeker individually before the Master's table, following the usual manner. He removes the letter "S" as previously described and returns it to the kneeling stool after the pledge. The Instruction Master then instructs the Seeker to kneel on both knees.

WM: The rules and regulations of our Order teach us to unite in the bond of brotherly affection, committed to the lasting moral welfare of every member and to be of service under all circumstances.

Thus, we have voluntarily pledged ourselves to a sacred covenant—one that obliges us to guard the secrets of our Order from the outside world. We trust that you will never, under any condition, be tempted to break the vow you have freely given.

Should you betray this fraternity and dishonor this covenant by violating the trust now placed in you, you would forfeit all claim to our future confidence. Your conscience alone would declare you unworthy—unfit for any society.

But if you act with integrity and uphold the duties and traditions of our Order, you will earn the esteem and respect of all its members. Therefore, you must seek your own happiness, advance the benevolent mission of our Order, and strive to be a blessing to all humankind.

Do you vow to fulfill these objectives?

Seeker: I do.

WM: As a pledge of loyalty to the Order, you will now seal the Holy Scriptures once with your lips.

The seeker touches the Bible once with his lips.

WM: Arise, my brother/sister.

If there are several Admissions, continue here with the next seeker.

The WM addresses the lodge:

WM: My brothers/sisters, you may be seated.

The WM continues to stand, and the seeker also remains standing in front of the master table.

WM: Our Order may be described as a charitable society, composed of honorable individuals united by virtue, benevolence, and brotherhood.

“Do to others as you would have them do to you” (Luke 6:31), is our highest principle. Peace and harmony, along with the values of charity and goodwill towards all humankind, are the highest concern of our Order.

As Free Gardeners, it is our custom to gather and share knowledge, to support one another in times of need, and to offer encouragement in moments of sickness and sorrow. It is also our solemn duty to aid the helpless, to dry the tears of grief, and to bring comfort to the families of our departed members.

We uphold these principles in service to the human spirit—through acts of benevolence, expressions of affection, and steadfast commitment to truth.

Our rules and regulations call every Free Gardener to treat each other with fairness, offer unwavering support in all circumstances, and remain actively engaged with the world around us.

§11 Free Gardener-Apprentice: Sign, Token, Word and Motto

[Short pause, music if possible]

The Worthy Master instructs the seeker in the presence of the Instruction Master.

WM: I will now instruct you in the Sign, Token, Word and Motto of this degree.

The Sign *[The WM makes the sign]*

The apprentice sign consists of placing the ----- the ----- and after a short time ----- the --- ----- to the ----- t----. The ----- is placed ----- to the -----.

The token is ----- r----- of a -----.

The WM gives the Token to the seeker. (If there are several Admissions, the token is given to each one).

The word is ----, and is given in following manner:

The WM together with the IM.

WM: “Give me the word.”

IM: Give me the first letter.

WM: -

IM: -

WM: -

IM: -

WM: --

IM: --

WM and IM [say together]: ----.

WM: The Motto is ----- (Genesis 2:15).

An apprentice has the right to vote but not to speak in an open lodge. I call your attention to the Voting Sign. The left arm is held at a right angle from the body and the thumb is placed parallel to the remaining fingers. (All fingers point in the same direction).

The sign of reverence is given when we pray in the lodge and is performed as follows: --- ---- ---
----- are brought -- ----- -- the ----. The ----- of the ---- --- ----- w--- --- ----- . The insides
of --- ----- --- towards --- -----.

The WM goes back to his station. The Instruction Master conducts the seeker to the EM. The EM rises. (If there is more than one, this is done with all the seekers together.) The Instruction Master calls out the answers if the seekers need it:

Instruction Master: Emissary Master, I present to you Brother/Sister [First and Last Name].

EM: Do you have something to give me?

Seeker: Yes. The sign.

EM: Give me the sign.

[Seeker makes the sign.]

Secretary: It stands for the three forefathers of the Free Gardeners: Adam, Noah and Solomon.

EM: Do you have anything else to give me?

Seeker: Yes. The token.

EM: Give me the token.

[The seeker gives the token to the EM.]

Secretary: It represents the threefold art: operative gardening, metaphorical gardening and the mysteries of horticulture.

EM: Do you have anything else to give me?

Seeker: Yes. The word.

EM: Give me the word.

Seeker: Give me the first letter.

EM: -

Seeker: -

EM: -

Seeker: -

EM: --

Seeker: --

EM and Seeker [say together]: ----.

Secretary: It is the ---- -- --- very -----.

EM: Do you have anything else to give me?

Seeker: Yes. The motto.

EM: Give me the motto.

Seeker: -----.

Secretary: It means, -- -----!

[short pause]

EM: You have proven yourself to be an Apprentice-Free-Gardener and have begun to acquire knowledge of metaphorical gardening.

The Instruction Master conducts the seeker to the northeast before the secretary, who should be standing. If several Admissions, this section is done with all seekers together.

§12 Free Gardener-Apprentice: Reading of the Ancient Customs

WM: Brother Secretary, you will now read the “Ancient Customs of the Free Gardeners” (see §16), and have the seeker sign a copy of the same to seal the contract between him/her and the fraternity.

The secretary reads the Ancient Customs of the Free Gardeners. Afterwards, each seeker signs two identical copies of the same. One copy will be placed in the archives of the lodge and the other will serve as a Certificate to be presented in a frame after it has been recorded.

Secretary: Worthy Master, your order has been obeyed.

The Instruction Master then conducts the seeker(s) back to the western edge of the carpet (facing the WM)

Chaplain: Now the serpent was more crafty than any of the wild animals the Lord God had made. He said to the woman, “Did God really say, ‘You must not eat from any tree in the garden’?”

The woman said to the serpent, “We may eat fruit from the trees in the garden,

but God did say, ‘You must not eat fruit from the tree that is in the middle of the garden, and you must not touch it, or you will die.’”

“You will not certainly die,” the serpent said to the woman.

“For God knows that when you eat from it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God, knowing good and evil.”

When the woman saw that the fruit of the tree was good for food and pleasing to the eye, and also desirable for gaining wisdom, she took some and ate it. She also gave some to her husband, who was with her, and he ate it.

Then the eyes of both of them were opened, and they realized they were naked; so they sewed fig leaves together and made coverings [KJV - aprons] for themselves.

§13 Free Gardener-Apprentice: Apron

The Instruction Master ensures that all seekers step into the apprentice sign FROM NOW ON when walking or standing; to get used to it. The Instruction Master conducts the seeker(s) before the WM, who says:

WM: Just as Adam and Eve put on aprons of fig leaves as a sign that they henceforth would eat their bread by the sweat of their brow, you will now wear this apron of a Free Gardener-Apprentice.

The WM hands the apron to the seeker. The Instruction Master cannot help the seeker(s) put on the apron; they must do this by themselves. (If there are several Admissions, this section is done with all seekers together.)

WM: Dear Brother/Sister, we trust that this will increase your esteem and affection for the Order; and that in you we have found a worthy and faithful member, ready always to defend the customs of the Order. Henceforth, any phase of life that you may have to pass through will be adorned with virtue and your conduct with integrity; this will guarantee you the approval of your brothers and sisters.

By exemplifying the noble principles of friendship, truth, and love in your conduct, you will lay a foundation for lasting happiness and gain the respect of your fellow man.

[Short pause.]

WM: Dear brother/sister, welcome to our garden and to our ranks. I would like to congratulate you on planting your first seedling in metaphorical gardening.

The Instruction Master conducts the seeker to the northeast of the lodge and instructs them to be seated there. The Instruction Master returns to his place in the lodge.

§14 Free Gardener-Apprentice: Reading of the Story.

WM: Brother Secretary, read "The Story of the First Free Gardener."

Secretary rise and reads §17.

After a short break, the WM and the EM demonstrate Free Gardner Apprentice Catechism

§15 Free Gardener-Apprentice: Catechism

WM: For what purpose have we gathered?

EM: For pleasure, aid, and instruction.

WM: What aims guide the path of every Free Gardener?

EM: The comfort of a clear conscience, the faithful fulfilment of their duties, and the pleasure of seeing each member happy.

WM: How do members benefit from the Order?

EM: By contributing to the health and strength of fellow members, so that they may better cope with life's challenges and misfortunes.

WM: Why is the Lodge compared to a garden?

EM: Just as a garden has flowers, plants, shrubs and trees of different species, characteristics and merits, so does the Lodge welcome people of different opinions, backgrounds and abilities; and as a garden requires the hand of the cultivator to remove the harmful weeds and grow the more useful plants with delicate care, so does the spirit of man need guidance in education and philosophy - to eliminate envy, arrogance and laziness, which makes men useless.

The Free Gardener's special attention to the metaphorical garden leads to heightened virtue, philanthropy, and charity. The Lodge is comparable, in these and many other ways, to a garden. Therefore, we call ourselves Free Gardeners; but we must always remember that it is not the title which makes a true Free Gardener, but the honorable principles that should adorn their conduct.

WM: My esteemed brothers and sisters, I will now further induct you into our Order as Free Gardener-Apprentice. This lowest degree is the humblest but also the most honorable of all degrees. We call it the Degree of the ----- . That is why the Hebrew word ----- was chosen as a motto, which means "-- -----", and refers to the word of this degree, ---- (Genesis 2:15). The word and motto of this degree together means "---- -----" or "---- ----- c---".

EM: The three tools on the upper flap of your apron are the compass, the square and the pruning knife. They are considered the general tools of our Order. The compass is the tool of God the Creator, who conceives, develops, shapes, and creates the world with the stroke of a compass. The square is the tool by which he directs human actions with genuine love (1st virtue), divine wisdom (2nd virtue), true harmony (3rd virtue), and eternal truth (4th virtue).

With the gardener's simplest tool and the Free Gardener's highest ornament - the pruning knife – God - the Supreme Gardener of the Universe – reaches out and intervenes in creation. With it, he influences the development of nature and the evolution of man by cutting away the vices and engrafting virtues. The four sections on the apron and the four symbols in each section can represent the four elements, but also the Four Kingdoms of Nature, which are the mineral, plant, animal, and human kingdoms. Each of these kingdoms contains the four elements, but only one of them has dominion over the other three.

WM: Through obedience and diligence, through care and prudence, through the cultivation of unwavering affection, charity and benevolence, you will soon attain the degree of a Journeyman Free Gardener. To do this, you must apply the knowledge you have gained here, such as

removing the weeds of pride and complacency from your garden, which represents your innermost being. Walk the paths of humility laid out in the garden so that your conduct reflects your calling.

You will be placed under the supervision and guidance of the Keepers of the Garden, to whom you owe reverence and respect, and whose benevolence, admonishment and constructive correction you should accept with patience, gentleness and compliance. You must pay due respect to the Keepers, not for the sake of office alone, but because one day you may also be called upon to assume office yourself.

The spirit of man is like a bud or a seed, in which the very essence of life is centered. It can unfold to unimagined sustainable growth if it is properly cared for. For no spiritual or mental abilities are more generally neglected than those of observation and reflection. Mankind sees and hears things without paying proper attention; without giving them the time to leave an impression on their own minds. Hence comes the falsification of Ideas and the blurring of memories. Take in your observations accurately and attentively so that your mind becomes a rich treasure trove of possibilities and a true storehouse of the past, available to you in the future phases of your life.

If possible, learn about each tree, plant and flower you observe within your own surroundings and; their systematic and symmetrical proportions, as well as the collective relationships that exist among all living things, and the impressive interdependencies by which all life is connected. You will thus become aware of cosmic nature and develop refreshing associations and life-giving impulses during your morning and evening walks that less attentive people will miss for the rest of their lives.

Let no evil disposition take possession of your mind!

Be honest, sincere, and truthful not only for your own sake, but also for the sake of all creation. Through this conduct, your life will be virtuous and happy. Let the highest of our principles, "Do to others as you would have them do to you." be the basic law of your soul and the guiding principle of your actions!

EM: Esteemed Free Gardeners, the public for the most part approaches us with questions that should at least be answered in general terms.

WM: What is Free Gardening?

EM: Free Gardening is understood as the mindful treatment of the earth, related to metaphorical cultivation of the spirit, soul, and virtues.

WM: What is a Free Gardener?

EM: A Free Gardener is a free person who seeks to create paradise within. Because he sees the garden as a spiritual and metaphorical reflection of himself.

WM: What is the task of a Free Gardener?

EM: A Free Gardener conceives, develops, shapes and creates a metaphorical garden that is ultimately himself, to make the world a paradise again.

WM: What is the attitude of the Free Gardeners?

EM: Their attitude corresponds to a profound affection towards the Creator, creation, nature, and man, which is expressed in their virtues.

WM: What are the virtues of the Free Gardeners?

EM: The Free Gardeners cherish the virtues of love, wisdom, harmony, and truth. They use them as an effective means to make the inner, as well as the outer garden, flourish.

§16 Free Gardener-Apprentice: The Ancient Customs of Free Gardeners

§1. Honor the Supreme Gardener of the Universe (God), who created and sustains creation, nature and man, and maintains them every day.

§2. “Do to others as you would have them do to you.” Show them the same care you wish for yourself, and do not postpone until tomorrow that care you could give them today.

§3. Break thy bread with the hungry, comfort the sorrowful, help the erring to understand the right. And let widows, orphans, and the poor find a safe refuge in your garden.

§4. Donate your strength and resources for the good of the whole. Have reverence for old age; it possesses the fruits of wisdom and experience. Our ancestors planted the trees that today provide us with protective shade. Be respectful to elders, compassionate to the young, kind, and helpful to all.

§5. Seek to become useful through your own spiritual evolution. Sloth is the beginning of all misery. Through diligence we find peace and satisfaction after the fulfillment of our duty. These are the true fruits of a Free Gardener.

§6. Never allow anyone in your presence to be robbed of his good name and reputation. Sow peace and harmony among people and you will reap contentment.

§7. Avert harm and disadvantage from the members and do not conceal from them anything that goes against the purpose, the honor and the continuity of Free Gardening and the Order. Especially do not conceal anything from your Worthy Master.

§8. Live according to the Free Gardeners' duties, customs, statutes, and rules. Show respect to all members and especially to the Worthy Master and the Keepers. With your conduct, be a good example to the younger members.

§9. Contribute with all your strength and means to the reputation and prosperity of the Free Gardeners and never evade the toils, troubles, and labors to which you are called. Always offer your help to the community.

§10. Always weigh your words. Be sparing with promises, but faithful in their fulfillment. What you say shall be truth, and what you promise shall be solid.

The contracts to be signed by the apprentice Free Gardeners shall conclude with the following:

With my signature I, (full name is written in block letters), seal the contract

between the Free Gardeners and me. I acknowledge it to be a legally binding document.

(There will be two signature fields at the end of the document, including the date and place field.)

§17 Free Gardener-Apprentice: The Story of the First Free Gardener

The moral teachings of our Order are based on the metaphorical and operative craft and its reference to the Old Testament; the craft of the gardener is understood as the oldest profession practiced by man.

In the first book (Genesis 2:8) it says: " And the Lord God made a garden in the east, in Eden; and there he put the man whom he had formed." thus is the place, the time and the doer; with verse 15 in which it says "And the Lord God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to do work in it and take care of it." also explains the task of man. The very first gardener in the very first Garden was none other than Adam, and the Garden in Eden was a place whose perfection reflected his own. So, all he had to do was to cultivate, preserve, keep, and take care of the garden. Certainly, a minor task in the operative sense, for in such a perfect place it could only be a ceremonial task, therefore one speaks of metaphorical gardening or of the Free Gardening.

Adam could eat all the fruit in the garden in Eden. However, he was strongly warned never to eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. He was even warned of the dire consequences: that he would certainly die (Genesis 2:17), that his physical immortality would be stripped away. The field would be cursed for his sake for all generations after him and he would have to live on it with sorrow all his life (Genesis 3:17). Thorns and thistles would grow in the field (Genesis 3:18) and he would have to eat his bread by the sweat of his brow until he returns to the earth from which he came (Genesis 3:19).

God, the Supreme Gardener of the Universe, sensed Adam's loneliness and created Eve, made from Adam's rib to be his equal companion. Finally, the serpent tempted Eve, who in turn tempted Adam, and they both ate the fruit of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil and lost their innocence. The garden of Eden could no longer reflect man's former perfection and sprouted thorns and thistles - the worst nuisance for a gardener.

God had man expelled from the garden of Eden so that the garden could return to its perfect state. However, man's longing for his homeland and former state of perfection continued growing from generation to generation.

Adam had to transfer his knowledge of metaphorical gardening into an operative craft to survive. He became an operative gardener. Remembering his perfection, but especially that of the garden in Eden, he sought through operative horticulture, to restore the perfect state in the world. Thorns, thistles, weeds and pests became psychological manifestations of the loss of his innocence, and so he spends the rest of his existence driving them out of his garden, metaphorically, out of his life.

§18 Free Gardener-Apprentice Lodge: Closing

Before the lodge closes, the WM indicates to the chaplain that he intends to close the lodge:

WM: Brother Chaplain, I am about to close the lodge. Arrange the carpet accordingly!

The chaplain then arranges the carpet so that only the rake, spade, scythe and serpent remain. When the chaplain has returned to his seat, the WM says:

WM: All rise!

WM: Emissary Master, what duty now remains?

EM: To close the lodge, Worthy Master.

WM: Before the lodge is closed, let us unite in prayer.

[All give and hold the sign of reverence until the second Amen is returned.]

Chaplain: Supreme Gardener of the Universe, grant our souls rest and contentment after duty here on earth is done; that our labor may be to the glory of Thy holy name. Amen.

All: Amen.

WM: In the name of the Supreme Gardener of the Universe, I declare this lodge duly closed.

EM: And it shall remain closed until it becomes necessary to assemble once more.

WM: Emissary Master, what is our final duty before we depart?

EM: To remember the treasury, Worthy Master.

WM: Rentmaster, perform your duty.

The RM begins to collect in the south, to the west, then in the north to the east, and after the donation from the WM he puts his own donation in the bag in front of the WM and only then returns to his place and says, still standing, in the direction of the WM:

RM: Worthy Master, your order has been obeyed.

WM: Before I dismiss you, I would like to thank you for your presence here today and for your generous support. May you always carry the olive branch of peace, to show the world that love, wisdom, harmony and truth are the highest virtues of our Order. Keep in mind the motto that has been handed down to us from time immemorial: "Therefore keep watch, because you do not know the day or the hour." (Matthew 25:13).

[The chaplain solemnly closes the Bible and returns to his seat.]

The EM addresses the lodge after the chaplain has sat down, giving a short pause before speaking:

EM: So be it done!

WM: Go out into the world and plant seeds of harmony, peace, and friendship among the people.

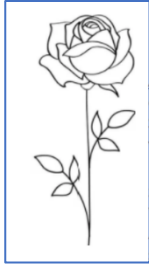
After the pronouncement of the WM and a short pause, the Gatekeeper opens the gate, goes through and remains standing in front of it outside of the Lodge. The Keyholder remains standing in front of the gate inside the Lodge. [Music]

§19 Free Gardener-Journeyman: Opening



In the second degree, the letter "A" is placed in the upper left corner of the carpet and the snake is centered below it. The three concentric circles are centered above the rake. The four letters of the streams (PGHE), the rake, the spade and the scythe are arranged as in the preceding degree. Members enter the garden when the gate has been opened, and the Gatekeeper invites them to enter.

The Worthy Master (WM) and the other keepers stand without giving the general sign as the members enter. The members remain silent as they take their seats – music may be played as the members enter and continues playing until the gate is closed. Once the door is knocked on, private conversations should be avoided. Those wishing to address the lodge during the meeting must inform the secretary beforehand and he will inform the Worthy Master. All Keepers and the WM will take their seats before the WM proceeds to open the lodge.



Attention: *Before the ceremonial opening the Chaplain will remove the white rose from the West Altar and place it on the table of the EM.*

The Instruction Master ensures that there are plenty of seats in the southeast for the seekers.

When all members are seated and the lodge is silent, the Worthy Master gives three raps on the table with his Pruning Knife, which are answered by the Emissary Master (EM) with his Pruning Knife.

WM: ● ● ●

EM: ● ● ●

WM: All rise!

[All rise without giving a sign]

WM: Emissary Master, what is our first duty when opening a Journeyman's lodge?

EM: To confirm that the Keyholder is at his post, and carrying the key to the garden, Worthy Master.

The Keyholder raises the key for the Worthy Master to see. The Worthy Master acknowledges with a nod then turns back to the Emissary Master.

WM: Emissary Master, what is our next duty?

EM: To confirm that all present have attained the Journeyman Degree, Worthy Master.

WM: Emissary Master, perform your duty.

The Emissary Master examines everyone who is not known to him, or who he does not know, to have attained the Journeyman Degree.

EM: First, give me the apprentice sign.

Everyone makes the Apprentice Sign in the direction of the Emissary Master except the EM himself and the WM.

EM: Now give me the Journeyman sign.

All make the Journeyman's Sign in the direction of the Emissary Master except the EM himself and the WM. The EM turns to the WM and says:

EM: Worthy Master, I can vouch for all who are present.

The EM makes the Journeyman's sign in the direction of the Worthy Master. The WM does not return it.

WM: Let us unite in prayer before the lodge is opened.

All members give and hold the Sign of Reverence until the prayer concludes [second amen].

Chaplain: Supreme Gardener, Father of all Gardeners, who manifests His infinite majesty, power, and goodness among us here on earth. We thank You for having planted the fruits of humanity in a garden long ago and having placed us among Your wondrous creations. Amen.

All: Amen.

WM: Worthy Keepers, brothers and sisters, we gather here today in agreement with the customs of the Journeyman's Degree. I ask for your patience and undivided attention during. Remain centered and undistracted by the world's temptations and committed to the common good. May our assembly be guided by order, peace, and harmony.

The chaplain goes to the master's table and opens the Bible to Genesis 9:1. To his left, as seen from his position, the compass, square, and pruning knife are arranged on the Master's table. The WM waits until the chaplain has returned to his seat:

WM: In the name of the Supreme Gardener of the Universe, I declare this Journeyman lodge duly open.

EM: So be it done!

WM: Brothers and sisters, you may now be seated.

The Worthy Master proceeds to ask the following questions if there are admissions. Otherwise, the approved AOFG Lodge Agenda is used.

WM: Brother Secretary, have any apologies [for absence] or other communications been received?

Secretary: [Replies: Worthy Master, ...]

WM: Brother Secretary, has any member recently done something that deserves recognition—either for their contribution to our lodge or the Order as a whole?

Secretary: [Replies: Worthy Master, ...]

WM: Brother Secretary, does any member wish to present a suggestion, proposal, or recommendation?

Secretary: [Replies: Worthy Master, ...]

WM: Brother Secretary, have any seekers been recommended for the Journeyman Degree?

Secretary: [Replies: Worthy Master, ...]

If the Secretary responds in the affirmative, the Gatekeeper quietly retires—without prompting—to prepare the first seeker(s).

§20 Free Gardener-Journeyman: Entrance

The Gatekeeper signals the Keyholder by making noises that a seeker is standing in front of the gate. Keyholder:

Keyholder: Worthy Master, there are noises at the gate.

Worthy Master: Brother Keyholder, see who is there.

The Keyholder opens the gate and addresses the Gatekeeper.

Keyholder: Who goes there?

Gatekeeper: It is the Free Gardener Apprentice [First and Last Name] who desires to further his knowledge of gardening, metaphorical gardening and the mysteries of horticulture.

The Keyholder closes the door, holds up the key and says:

Keyholder: Worthy Master, it is our Gatekeeper with the apprentice [First and Last Name], who desires to further his knowledge of gardening, metaphorical gardening and the mysteries of horticulture.

WM: Then let us help him/her fulfill this desire.

WM: Instruction Master, perform the duty of your office and confirm whether he/she is worthy of Admission.

The Instruction Master goes to the gate, the Keyholder opens the gate for him, and then lets the seeker enter under the guidance of the Gatekeeper, who leads him by the right hand. - The Keyholder quietly closes the gate behind them both.

§21 Free Gardener-Journeyman: Admission

The Instruction Master conducts the seeker before the Emissary Master, who demands from him the sign, the token, the word, and the motto of the Apprentice Degree. He may also ask for further advanced knowledge of the Apprentice Degree. (see §11).

EM: As an apprentice, have you sought knowledge of gardening, metaphorical gardening, and the mysteries of horticulture?

Seeker: I have.

EM: Have you implemented the highest virtues our Order - love, wisdom, harmony, and truth – in your own life?

Seeker: I have.

EM: Have you refrained from using words or actions that cause division, and instead worked to uphold order, peace, unity, and harmony among the members?

Seeker: I have.

EM: Worthy Master, the seeker has identified himself as an Apprentice Free Gardener.

The WM addresses the lodge:

WM: Dear brothers and sisters, has the apprentice served his time, and are his masters and journeymen satisfied with his work? If so, then say now collectively: We are satisfied?

ALL: We are satisfied.

WM: Dear brothers and sisters, do you consent to this apprentice being admitted as a Journeyman? If so, then say collectively: We consent.

ALL: We consent.

If there is only one Apprentice for Admission, the Instruction Master and the Apprentice remain standing in the west, facing the EM.

WM: All rise!

The EM holds up a white rose and shows it to the seekers. The Instruction Master remains standing with the seekers.

EM: Dear apprentice, I would like to remind you of the white rose; a symbol of innocence and virtue. The immaculate color of its petals represents the purity of the human spirit, which wards off the attacks of wickedness. Its fragrance, especially when its petals wither and die, is comparable to the fragrance of a loved one, who lived with honesty and integrity.

May the fragrance of the white rose correspond with your good deeds. A fragrance is the strongest means of remembrance.

Spend a long and happy life with your Loved Ones. Let your future conduct be such that it will further gain the loving respect and admiration of your family and friends. Therefore, observe carefully what our Order requires of you and never bring dishonor upon yourself, upon us, or the Creator.

Are you ready to commit yourself to these ideas?

Seeker: I am.

If there are multiple Admissions, at this point, the seeker is seated in the southeast of the Lodge and a new apprentice is introduced in the same manner as the first one.

Once all the apprentices are seated in the southeast, the Instruction Master has the apprentices stand up together. They hold hands and follow the Instruction Master. They walk to the west before the EM's table.

EM: Now, dear apprentice(s), I commend you to our Worthy Master. Follow his guidance and instructions with innermost conviction.

§23 Free Gardener-Journeyman: Vow

The seeker is led by the Instruction Master before the Master's table. On the kneeling stool is the letter "S", which is to be removed by the Instruction Master and placed on the master's table before the seeker kneels. The Instruction Master directs the seeker to kneel on both knees. After the vow, the letter "S" is immediately returned to the kneeling stool by the Instruction Master. If there is more than one seeker, §23 is to be performed with each seeker individually.

Note: When kneeling during the Journeyman Degree, the seeker shall make and maintain the Apprentice Sign during his vow. The seeker is not permitted to touch the master's table during the vow. The WM says to the apprentice:

WM: Dear apprentice(s), in the presence of all gathered here, you are now called to renew the vow you have already made: to treat one another with courtesy; to keep the secrets of the Journeyman Degree from those who are not initiated; to never bring harm to others, especially fellow members of our Order; and to offer help in peaceful ways, whenever it is within your power. Are you willing to accept this Vow?

Seeker: I am.

WM: As confirmation of your loyalty, you will now seal the Scriptures twice with your lips.

Seeker touches the Bible twice with his lips.

WM: Arise, my brother/sister.

The Instruction Master assists the Journeyman to rise. WM addresses the lodge:

WM: My brothers and Sister, you may be seated.

§24 Free Gardener-Journeyman: Bible Reading (NOAH)

The Instruction Master escorts the seeker to the west end of the Carpet. (When all seekers are standing there, the chaplain begins).

Chaplain: "And God blessed Noah and his sons and said to them, 'Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth'" (Genesis 9:1)

The chaplain takes the letter "N" from his table, holds it up and says in the direction of the Seeker(s):

Chaplain: NOAH

The chaplain then places the letter "N" on the Carpet and returns to his seat.

Chaplain: The fear and dread of you will fall on all the beasts of the earth, and on all the birds in the sky, on every creature that moves along the ground, and on all the fish in the sea; they are given into your hands. Everything that lives and moves about will be food for you. Just as I gave you the green plants, I now give you everything. But you must not eat meat that has its lifeblood

still in it. And for your lifeblood I will surely demand an accounting. I will demand an accounting from every animal. And from each human being, too, I will demand an accounting for the life of another human being. Whoever sheds human blood, by humans shall their blood be shed; for in the image of God has God made mankind.

As for you, be fruitful and increase in number; multiply on the earth and increase upon it. Then God said to Noah and to his sons with him: “I now establish my covenant with you and with your descendants after you and with every living creature that was with you—the birds, the livestock and all the wild animals, all those that came out of the ark with you—every living creature on earth. I establish my covenant with you: Never again will all life be destroyed by the waters of a flood; never again will there be a flood to destroy the earth.” And God said, “This is the sign of the covenant I am making between me and you and every living creature with you, a covenant for all generations to come: I have set my rainbow in the clouds, and it will be the sign of the covenant between me and the earth.

Whenever I bring clouds over the earth and the rainbow appears in the clouds, I will remember my covenant between me and you and all living creatures of every kind. Never again will the waters become a flood to destroy all life. (Genesis 9:2-15)

[Short pause.]

The WM addresses the lodge:

WM: Rise my brothers and sisters --- and make yourselves known. Point to the rainbow on your apron.

All except the chaplain rise and point with the index finger of the right hand to the lower edge of their apron where the ark, dove and rainbow are located, until the chaplain has finished reading the following passage:

Chaplain: “Whenever the rainbow appears in the clouds, I will see it and remember the everlasting covenant between God and all living creatures of every kind on the earth.” So God said to Noah, “This is the sign of the covenant I have established between me and all life on the earth.” The sons of Noah who came out of the ark were Shem, Ham and Japheth. (Ham was the father of Canaan.) These were the three sons of Noah, and from them came the people who were scattered over the whole earth. Noah, a man of the soil, proceeded to plant a vineyard. (Genesis 9:16-20)

[Short pause.] All members stop pointing. WM addresses the lodge:

WM: My brothers and sisters, you may be seated.

[Short pause.]

§25 Free Gardener-Journeyman: Sash

The Instruction Master leads the seeker(s) to the WM:

WM: Just as God put the sign of the covenant - the rainbow – across the heavens like a sash, so I adorn you with this starry sign of hope.

The WM puts the sash on the seeker (right shoulder to left hip). If there is more than one seeker, this section is done with all seekers together, the WM putting the sash on each of them.

After a short pause, the WM continues:

WM: Dear brother/sister, you are now a Journeyman of our Order. We place great confidence in the sincerity of your vow given today and fully anticipate your future development. Always strive and seek our admiration and esteem.

Strengthen our Order and its members through diligence, friendship, and affection. Sow the seeds of peace and harmony, and foster order, prudence, and unity in all our assemblies.

We hold in high regard a sincere commitment to both our profession and our vocation. Therefore, study well the principles of our Order, which rest upon charity and benevolence. Be ever willing to assist the needy and those in distress, whenever it lies within your power.

Let your conduct always reflect the highest standards of honesty and decency. Just as a garden is tended according to its natural needs, so must we tend the metaphorical garden of our character and actions. Let your dealings with the world be guided by our foremost principle: “Do to others as you would have them do to you.”

Strive for peace and harmony; live in accord with all humanity. Shun strife and promote goodness wherever you go. Give due respect to those who lead by merit or ability and extend kindness toward those less fortunate than yourself.

Avoid intemperance and debauchery, for these are the seeds of irrational, destructive, and criminal behavior. By faithfully observing these rules, you shall enhance your reputation, and by contributing to the joy of our fellowship, your own happiness shall increase.

The WM and the Instruction Master take the seeker(s) between them. The Instruction Master stands at one end of the line with the WM standing before the line. The WM addresses the lodge:

WM: Dear brothers and sisters, I present to you our newly initiated Journeyman. I commend this member to your kindness and thoughtful care. May you receive them with generosity of spirit, and uphold the trust placed in you by honoring the secrets of our Order with sincerity and respect.

[Short pause, music may be played]

§26 Free Gardener-Journeyman: Sign, Token, Word and Motto

The Worthy Master instructs the seeker in the presence of the Instruction Master.

WM: I will now instruct you in the Sign, Token, Word and Motto of this degree.

The Sign [*The WM makes the sign*]

The Journeyman Sign consists of the m----- -- ----- -- the ---- ---- then --- ---- -----.

The Token is ----- of a -----, with --- ----- p----- ---- and ----- against each other.

The WM demonstrates with the seeker. (If there are several Admissions, the token is given to each one).

The word is: ----, and is given in the following manner:

The WM together with the IM.

WM: Give me the word.

IM: Give me the first letter.

WM: -

IM: -

WM: -

IM: -

WM: --

IM: --

WM and IM [*say together*]: ----.

WM: The motto is ----- (Genesis 5:29)

WM: An apprentice does not have the right to speak in an open lodge, but a Journeyman does. I call your attention to the Speaking Sign.

The ----- -- h--- -- a ----- f--- -- ---- and the ---- -- ----- ---- a-- ----- -----.

The Instruction Master brings the seeker before the EM.

IM: Emissary Master, I present to you Brother/Sister [First and Last Name].

EM: Brother/Sister [First and Last Name], do you have something to give me?

Seeker: Yes. The Sign.

EM: Give me the sign.

Seeker makes the sign.

Secretary: It means that the Free Gardener should ----- any -----.

EM: Do you have anything else to give me?

Seeker: Yes. The token.

EM: Give me the token.

Seeker gives the token to the EM.

Secretary: It represents the ----- a----- of the ---- -----; ----, ---- and -----, and the ----- b-----, which is represented by --- ----- which -- ---- f---.

EM: Do you have anything else to give with me?

Seeker: Yes. The word.

EM: Give me the word.

Seeker: Give me the first letter.

EM: -

Seeker: -

EM: -

Seeker: -

EM: --

Seeker: --

EM and Seeker /say together/: ----.

Secretary: It is the name of the ----- ----- -----.

EM: Do you have anything else to give me?

Seeker: Yes. The motto.

EM: Give me the motto.

Seeker: -----.

Secretary: It means – -- -----!

The Instruction Master leads the seeker(s) together before the Master's Table in the East.

WM: Brother/Sister [First and Last Name], we welcome you to our garden and the rank of Journeyman. I offer you heartfelt congratulations, for your seedling has begun to sprout in the metaphorical garden.

The Instruction Master leads the Seeker to a seat in the southeast of the Lodge.

§27 Free Gardener-Journeyman: Reading of the Story.

WM: Brother Secretary, read "The History of the First Free Gardener after the Flood."

The secretary stands and reads §29.

WM and the EM demonstrate the Free Gardener-Journeyman Catechism, §28.

§28 Free Gardener-Journeyman: Catechism

WM: For what purpose have we gathered?

EM: For pleasure, aid, and instruction.

WM: What aims guide the path of every Free Gardener?

EM: The comfort of a clear conscience, the faithful fulfilment of their duties, and the pleasure of seeing each member happy.

WM: How do members benefit from the Order?

EM: By contributing to the health and strength of fellow members, so that they may better cope with life's challenges and misfortunes.

WM: Why is the Lodge compared to a garden?

EM: Just as a garden has flowers, plants, shrubs and trees of different species, characteristics and merits, so does the Lodge welcome people of different opinions, backgrounds and abilities; and as a garden requires the hand of the cultivator to remove the harmful weeds and grow the more useful plants with delicate care, so does the spirit of man need guidance in education and philosophy - to eliminate envy, arrogance and laziness, which makes men useless.

That is why we call ourselves Free Gardeners; but we must always remember that it is not the title, but the honorable principles that should adorn our conduct that makes us true Free Gardener.

WM: My esteemed brothers and sisters, I will now further induct you into our Order as a Free Gardener-Journeyman. This degree is the midpoint but also the unifying degree. We call it the Degree of ----- . For this reason, the Hebrew word ----- was chosen as its motto, which means "-- ----- or -----", and refers to the word of this degree, ---- (Genesis 5:29). The Word and Motto of this degree together means "---- ----" or "---- ----".

EM: The apron of the Free Gardeners, which you received as an apprentice, contains a large portion of the symbols of our Order.

On the apron are four groups of symbols. Its base is black or dark blue, symbolizing that as an apprentice, you were still in the dark concerning the knowledge of Free Gardening. The four sections on the apron, each containing four symbols, represent the four elements and the Four Kingdoms of Nature, as taught in the Apprentice Degree. They also correspond to the galactic,

planetary, celestial, and terrestrial worlds. Within each world, the four elements are present, though only one element is dominant over the others.

Depicted on the flap of the apron are the All-Seeing Eye of God and the three tools of the Free Gardener: The Compass, Square, and Free Pruning Knife. The All-Seeing Eye signifies divine omnipresence, as belief in a supreme being is a prerequisite for admission into our brotherhood.

WM: The spatial separation of the upper group of symbols on the flap from the rest of the apron is meant to signify the transcendence of the upper area, clearly marked by the dominance of the All-Seeing Eye of God.

The first group of letters on the apron represents the four rivers that flowed from the center of the Garden of Eden: Pishon, Gihon, Hiddekel (Tigris), and Euphrates. These rivers, known to you from the Apprentice Degree, may also be interpreted as representing the four virtues of Free Gardening: Love, Wisdom, Harmony, and Truth.

The next group of letters—S, O, N, and A—stands for Solomon, Noah, and Adam. The order is not chronological, and the letter O does not represent a biblical figure, but rather the olive branch or olive tree. While the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil is often misidentified as an apple tree, the second tree at the center of the Garden of Paradise is more accurately interpreted as an olive tree.

The letters may be read counterclockwise. In the tradition of the Lodge, walking clockwise reflects the sun's path and symbolizes time; walking counterclockwise represents space. Noah's ark (Genesis 7:1-10), the rainbow (Genesis 9:8-17), the dove and the green olive branch (Genesis 8:6-12) are the symbols on the lowest section of the apron. These four symbols allude to three passages of the Old Testament that were read by the chaplain during your initiation as a Free Gardener-Journeyman.

EM: The Free Gardener-Journeyman wears a dark blue sash trimmed in gold, worn diagonally from the top right to the bottom left, along with the apron of the apprentice. Positioned at heart level is a star, within which are the insignia of Free Gardening: The Compass, Square, and Pruning Knife—symbols whose meaning was explained during your Apprentice Degree.

The sash, adorned with an eight-pointed star, serves as a reminder that a Free Gardener must remain noble and courteous, no matter which of the eight winds may guide his path. It is the only ceremonial garment permitted outside the Lodge during processions or public events, and only with the approval of the Worthy Master.

WM: Noah had taken onto the ark all kinds of seeds and seedlings from the Garden of Eden. The four main streams that poured into the world from the Eden carried with them all kinds of seeds, seedlings, branches and foliage.

Noah walked along the four main streams of Eden to find and collect seeds, seedlings, and saplings from the garden of Eden, which had been closed to man since the exile of Adam and Eve.

Since then, all Free Gardeners have been wandering for seedlings and saplings which ultimately represent diligence, friendship, and affection.

EM: His sons first wandered after the Flood, just as their father had done before, in search of sprouts and seedlings. Later, it became a common tradition to wander likewise to Noah and his sons.

Eventually, the wandering that began in the Garden of Eden (Genesis 2:8) was entrusted to the journey of the Free Gardener. Our Degrees symbolize the journey of humanity: from Adam and Eve, who represent the birth of mankind, to Noah's vineyards, which signify childhood and youth; to the grove of nut trees (Psalms 6:11), which reflects middle age. The Royal Garden (2 Kings 9:27; 21:18; 21:26), laid out around the temple, signifies old age—bearing the fruits of wisdom and experience, yet also representing death, as both the garden and temple were eventually destroyed.

The Garden of Gethsemane, known in Hebrew as Gat-Sh'manim (gaht sh-mah-neem) (גַּת שְׁמָנִים), is a symbol of rebirth, for Yeshua (shortened form of *Yehoshua*) of Nazareth went there to pray and found strength and understanding after struggling with the will of God (Matthew 26:36-50). This moment alludes to Paradise (Revelation 22:2), reminding us that the future garden of paradise must be cultivated within ourselves—through the nurturing of our virtues.

WM: Dear brother/sister, in the Journeyman's Degree, your attention is especially drawn to the three concentric circles upon the carpet. Just as Noah once journeyed along the four great rivers of paradise to gather seeds, seedlings, and saplings flowing from the Garden of Eden, so too do these circles allegorically represent that sacred wandering. The outer circle symbolizes the world, the middle circle—our Order, and the inner circle—the individual.

The external task of the Free Gardener-Journeyman is to move through the world with diligence, care, and attentiveness, to become competent in their craft as a metaphorical gardener. The inner task is to learn how to draw forth the soothing balm of consolation from the true principles of metaphorical gardening.

§29 Free Gardener-Journeyman: History of the First Free Gardener after the Flood.

The moral teachings of our Order are rooted in both the metaphorical and operative craft of gardening and its connection to the Old Testament, for the craft of gardening is understood as the oldest profession practiced by humankind. God expelled mankind from the Garden of Eden so that the garden could be restored to its perfect state. Yet mankind retained knowledge of metaphorical gardening and the operative craft, using it to survive. In remembrance of his lost perfection—especially that of Eden—man sought to restore the world to its perfect state through the practice of horticulture.

Noah was the first man Adam did not know personally. Lemek/Lamech (lay-mehk), Noah's father of one hundred and eighty-two years, blessed him at birth, saying: "Truly, he will give us rest from our trouble and the hard work of our hands, because of the earth which was cursed by God." (Genesis 5:29). Adam had spent his life trying to drive out the thorns, thistles, weeds, and pests—symbolic manifestations of his lost purity. When Adam died, these took hold, and thus it is written: "Now the earth was corrupt in God's sight and was full of violence." (Genesis 6:11). But Noah, who had learned both operative and metaphorical gardening from his father and mastered them, was shown divine favor: "But Noah found favor in the eyes of the Lord." (Genesis 6:8). He was commissioned to build the ark (Genesis 6:14). Within the ark, operative gardening could not be practiced in the usual sense—it became a ceremonial craft.

Noah and his wife, along with their sons Shem, Ham, and Japheth and their wives, practiced metaphorical gardening aboard the ark. Noah served as Worthy Master and is therefore regarded as the first Free Gardener after the Flood. In later generations, Free Gardener lodges were established by eight Keepers, as it requires one Master to found a lodge, four Master Gardeners to open it, and eight Masters or Keepers to conduct initiations.

After the Flood, God set the rainbow across the sky as a sign of the covenant. In turn, Noah placed a sash upon the survivors of the Flood as a symbol of hope.

Before the Flood, Noah walked the rivers to gather seeds, seedlings, and saplings from the Garden of Eden, which had remained closed to humankind since the exile of Adam and Eve. Thus, all Free Gardener-Journeymen have been wandering ever since.

Noah received seven commandments that Free Gardeners continue to honor—known as the Noahide Laws (Genesis 9:1–13). Though strict, these divine laws could not shield Noah from the temptations of human longing.

After fulfilling God's command, Noah planted vineyards. He drank deeply, becoming intoxicated, driven by a bittersweet remembrance of Eden and sorrow for those lost in the flood. In his grief, he uncovered himself, seeking to imitate Adam in paradise. His youngest son, Ham, found him in this state and mocked him before his brothers. Shem and Japheth, however, taught by example: placing garments on their shoulders, they walked backward into the tent to cover their father's nakedness, respectfully turning their faces away so they would not see it (Genesis 9:20).

And so, it became a custom of the Free Gardeners: to help one another in times of need, to encourage in hours of sickness and sorrow, to support the helpless, to dry tears in mourning, and to comfort the bereaved.

§30 Free Gardener-Journeyman Lodge: Closing

Before the lodge closes, the WM indicates to the chaplain that he intends to close the lodge:

WM: Brother Chaplain, I am about to close the lodge. Arrange the carpet accordingly!

The chaplain arranges the carpet, removing all items except the rake, the spade, the scythe, placing the snake above the rake, as in the Apprentice Degree.

Note: The chaplain moves the white rose from the EM's table to the West Altar.

When the chaplain has returned to his seat, the WM says:

WM: All rise!

WM: Emissary Master, what duty now remains?

EM: To close the lodge, Worthy Master.

WM: Before the lodge is closed, let us unite in prayer.

[All give and hold the sign of reverence until the second Amen is returned.]

Chaplain: Supreme Gardener of the Universe, grant our souls rest and contentment after duty here on earth is done; that our labor may be to the glory of Thy holy name. Amen.

All: Amen.

WM: In the name of the Supreme Gardener of the Universe, I declare this lodge duly closed.

EM: And it shall remain closed until it becomes necessary to assemble once more.

WM: Emissary Master, what is our final duty before we depart?

EM: To remember the treasury, Worthy Master.

WM: Rentmaster, perform your duty.

The RM begins to collect in the south, to the west, then in the north to the east, and after the donation from the WM he puts his own donation in the bag in front of the WM and only then returns to his place and says, still standing, in the direction of the WM:

RM: Worthy Master, your order has been obeyed.

WM: Before I dismiss you, I would like to thank you for your presence here today and for your generous support. May you always carry the olive branch of peace, to show the world that love, wisdom, harmony and truth are the highest virtues of our Order. Keep in mind the motto that has been handed down to us from time immemorial: "Therefore keep watch, because you do not know the day or the hour." (Matthew 25:13).

[The chaplain solemnly closes the Bible and returns to his seat.]

The EM addresses the lodge after the chaplain has sat down, giving a short pause before speaking:

EM: So be it done!

WM: Go out into the world and plant seeds of harmony, peace, and friendship among the people.

After the pronouncement of the WM and a short pause, the Gatekeeper opens the gate, goes through and remains standing in front of it outside of the Lodge. The Keyholder, on the other hand, remains standing in front of the gate inside the Lodge.

[Music]

§31 Free Gardener-Master: Opening



The carpet of a lodge opened in the third degree shall include a rake, spade, scythe, along with the letters P,H,G, and E, a snake and the letter “A”, all in the same positions as the previous degree; the letter “N” is placed in the top left corner of the carpet; a beehive is centered above the rake with its entrance facing west; and the Three Concentric Circle are centered below the letter “N”. (see diagram)

Members enter the garden when the gate has been opened, and the Gatekeeper invites them to enter. The Worthy Master (WM) and the other keepers stand without giving the general sign as the members enter. The members remain silent as they take their seats – music may be played as the members enter and continues playing until the gate is closed. Once the door is knocked on, private conversations should be avoided. Those wishing to address the lodge during the meeting must inform the secretary beforehand and he will inform the Worthy Master. All Keepers and the WM will take their seats before the WW proceeds to open the lodge.

Attention: *The Instruction Master ensures there are seats in the southwest if there are seekers receiving the Master Gardener’s degree.*

The letter "O" must be on the right side of the Bible on the Master's Table. The compass, square and pruning knife are to be placed on the left.

When all members are seated and the lodge is silent, the Worthy Master gives three raps on the table with his Pruning Knife, which are answered by the Emissary Master (EM) with his Pruning Knife.

WM: ● ● ●

EM: ● ● ●

WM: All rise!

[All rise without giving a sign]

WM: Emissary Master, what is our first duty when opening a Master Gardner lodge?

EM: To confirm that the Keyholder is at his post, and carrying the key to the garden, Worthy Master.

The Keyholder raises the key for the Worthy Master to see. The Worthy Master acknowledges with a nod then turns back to the Emissary Master.

WM: Emissary Master, what is the next duty?

EM: To confirm that all present have attained the Master Gardener Degree, Worthy Master.

WM: Emissary Master, perform your duty.

The Emissary Master examines everyone who is not known to him, or who he does not know, to have attained the Master Gardener degree.

EM: First, give me the Apprentice sign.

Everyone makes the Apprentice Sign in the direction of the Emissary Master except the EM himself and the WM.

EM: Now give me the Journeyman sign.

All make the Journeyman's Sign in the direction of the Emissary Master except the EM himself and the WM.

EM: Now give me the Master sign.

All make the Master Sign in the direction of the Emissary Master except the EM himself and the WM. The EM turns to the WM and says:

EM: Worthy Master, I can vouch for all who are present.

The EM makes the Master sign in the direction of the Worthy Master. The WM does not return it.

WM: Let us unite in prayer before the lodge is opened.

All members give and hold the Sign of Reverence until the prayer concludes [second amen].

Chaplain: Supreme Gardener, Father of all Gardeners, who manifests His infinite majesty, power, and goodness among us here on earth. We thank You for having planted the fruits of humanity in a garden long ago and having placed us among Your wondrous creations. Amen.

All: Amen.

WM: Worthy Keepers, brothers and sisters, we gather here today in agreement with the customs of the Master Gardener Degree. I ask for your patience and undivided attention during. Remain centered and undistracted by the world's temptations and committed to the common good. May our assembly be guided by order, peace, and harmony.

The chaplain goes to the master table and opens the Bible to the 1st book of Kings 6:11. To his left, as seen from his position, the compass, square, and pruning knife are arranged on the Master's table. The WM waits until the chaplain has returned to his seat:

WM: In the name of the Supreme Gardener of the Universe, I declare this Master Gardener lodge duly open.

EM: So be it done!

WM: My brothers and sisters, you may be seated.

The Worthy Master proceeds to ask the following questions if there are admissions. Otherwise, the approved AOFG Lodge Agenda is used.

WM: Brother Secretary, have any apologies [for absence] or other communications been received?

Secretary: [Replies: Worthy Master, ...]

WM: Brother Secretary, has any member recently done something that deserves recognition—either for their contribution to our lodge or the Order as a whole?

Secretary: [Replies: Worthy Master, ...]

WM: Brother Secretary, does any member wish to present a suggestion, proposal, or recommendation?

Secretary: [Replies: Worthy Master, ...]

WM: Brother Secretary, have any seekers been recommended for the Master Gardener Degree?

Secretary: [Replies: Worthy Master, ...]

If the Secretary responds in the affirmative, the Gatekeeper quietly retires—without prompting—to prepare the first seeker(s).

§32 Free Gardener-Master: Entrance

The Gatekeeper signals the Keyholder by making noises that a seeker is standing in front of the gate. Keyholder:

Keyholder: Worthy Master, there are noises at the gate.

Worthy Master: Brother Keyholder, see who is there.

The Keyholder opens the gate and addresses the Gatekeeper.

Keyholder: Who goes there?

Gatekeeper: It is the Free Gardener Journeyman [First and Last Name] who desires to further his knowledge of gardening, metaphorical gardening and the mysteries of horticulture.

The Keyholder closes the door, holds up the key and says:

Keyholder: Worthy Master, it is our Gatekeeper with the Journeyman [First and Last Name], who desires to further his knowledge of gardening, metaphorical gardening and the mysteries of horticulture.

WM: Then let us help him/her fulfill this desire.

WM: Instruction Master, perform the duty of your office and confirm whether he/she is worthy of Admission.

The Instruction Master goes to the gate, the Keyholder opens the gate for him, and then lets the seeker enter under the guidance of the IM, who leads him to the EM. - The Keyholder quietly closes the gate behind them both.

§33 Free Gardener-Master: Admission

The Instruction Master conducts the seeker before the Emissary Master, who demands from him the sign, the token, the word, and the motto of the Apprentice Degree. He may also ask for further advanced knowledge of the apprentice and Journeyman Degrees; if he considers him well prepared, he addresses him as follows:

EM: Are you prepared to follow instructions and give them by yourself, for the welfare of the Order and for the prosperity of its members?

Seeker: I am.

EM: Are you willing to renew your vows, which you have already given, namely, never to reveal or betray by signs, words or actions, the secrets of our Order, and never to reveal the knowledge of the Master's Degree to the uninitiated?

Seeker: I am.

EM: Are you willing to pledge, in the presence of all gathered here, that you will never, under any circumstances, reveal the secrets of this degree to any other person - except to a Master Gardener whom you have examined?

Seeker: I am.

EM: Are you willing to abide by our customs, rules, statutes, and regulations, as well as the laws of the Order that have been adopted during a regular assembly; and always strive to maintain order and unity, as well as peace and harmony throughout the Order?

Seeker: I am.

EM: Worthy Master and esteemed Master Gardeners, the Seeker has duly identified himself as a Free Gardener-Journeyman.

The WM addresses the lodge:

WM: Dear brothers and sisters, has the Journeyman served their time, and are his masters satisfied with his work? If so, then say now collectively: We are satisfied.

ALL: We are satisfied.

WM: Dear brothers and sisters, do you consent to this Journeyman being admitted as a Master Gardener? If so, then say now collectively: We consent.

ALL: We consent.

If there is only one Journeyman for Admission, the Instruction Master and the Journeyman remain standing in the west, facing the EM; until all have consented.

The Instruction Master then instructs the seeker to turn towards the WM and goes to the right side of the seeker.

EM: Worthy Master and esteemed Master Gardeners, I find our brother/sister duly prepared and commend them to the care and affection of our metaphorical and royal Craft.

The EM takes his seat.

§34 Free Gardener-Master: General Duties

The seeker faces the WM, remaining still:

IM: Worthy Master, I commend our sister/brother to your care and instruction.

The WM addresses him as follows:

WM: Dear Sister/Brother, today you will make a solemn and voluntary pledge, witnessed by all who are gathered here in honor of this sacred bond between you and the Order. Your future conduct must reflect this vow and be guided by the customs, rules, and regulations that govern our Order.

By your own merit, you will henceforth be eligible to hold the highest offices within the Order. Yet, let pride or false ambition never tempt you to seek positions for which you are not prepared. To take pride in virtue, and to be ambitious in service for the right reasons, is always honorable.

Therefore, strive to grow through moral practice. Never let a chance to do good pass you by, and do not postpone until tomorrow the good you can do today.

Be honest with your God, your family, your friends, and yourself. You may not always have the means to be charitable financially or to aid those in difficult circumstances. Yet each of us can show kindness and respect, offer help where it is needed, and give comfort and care to the helpless and the suffering.

The masterful Order you now enter offers many opportunities to do good and to spread goodwill among humankind. Remember always: every act of charity is a double blessing—one for the giver, and one for the receiver. Be attentive and compassionate whenever you hear of a member in need, especially among those to whom you are now bound by a lasting friendship.

Let the customs, rules, and regulations of the Order guide your actions. These are the foundations of a long and joyful life, which every true Free Gardener wishes for you, out of sincere love. From this day forward, do you commit to live by this pledge? If so, then say now: I do.

Seeker: I do.

EM: Then, so be it done.

§35 Free Gardener-Master: Vow

The Instruction Master guides the seeker to the Master's table. On the kneeling stool rests the letter "S," which the Instruction Master removes and places on the Master's table—over the letter "O," already set there. The seeker is then instructed to kneel on both knees. After the pledge is made, the Instruction Master returns the letter "S" to its original position on the kneeling stool. The Worthy Master then addresses the lodge:

WM: Esteemed brothers and sisters, we hold the title of Master Gardener, and it is our duty to share with our community what this truly means.

The whole world may be seen as a garden, cultivated and cared for with a diversity of trees. Just as a child receives years of love, nurturing, and attention, so too does a seed grow until it is strong enough to be transplanted. An experienced gardener must tend to these young sprouts from different trees, bring them into their care, and arrange them purposefully for future growth—thus creating a garden that honors the art of gardening.

Each person in this garden we call the world is like a tree. Life begins as a seed, nurtured tenderly until buds of reason begin to sprout. With care and attention, this life is guided until it matures into a full-grown tree. The Master Gardener's role is to graft wisdom and virtue onto this tree, much like the qualities found in the heart of an honest person.

With proper care, the graft becomes one with the tree, yielding beautiful and nourishing fruits—for the joy and fulfillment of the Master Free Gardeners, for our Order, and for all humanity.

Our lodge, too, resembles a well-tended plot of land, where even the smallest space holds valuable trees. They grow together and support one another. Some shield their companions from the harsh northern winds; others offer relief from the scorching sun. In their unity, they protect and uphold each other. This is the natural strength of a like-minded fellowship.

This is why we join such a worthy fraternity: to shield each other from storms of adversity and to ease the suffering of those in need.

Are you willing to do this? If so, say now: I am.

Seeker: I am.

WM: As a pledge of loyalty, you will now seal the Holy Scriptures with your lips three times.

Seeker touches the Bible three times with his lips.

WM: Arise, my brother/sister.

If there are several Admissions, the seeker is placed in the southeast of the Garden, and a new Journeyman is introduced in the same way. When multiple Admissions are taking place, the final Journeyman should be placed in the southeast first. Then the following steps occur:

The Instruction Master places the letter "S" on the Chaplain's table after all Journeymen have been admitted. He then solemnly lifts the letter "O" from the Master's table, holds it up for all to see, and slowly lowers it onto the kneeling stool. Next, he moves the last Journeyman to the southwest.

Once all admitted Journeymen are seated in the southwest, the Instruction Master asks the newly made Master Gardeners to rise, join hands, and follow him to the west. They stop together in front of the West Altar, facing east.

The Worthy Master then addresses the lodge:

WM: My brothers and sisters, you may be seated.

§36 Free Gardener-Master: Reading of the Bible (SOLOMON)

The Instruction Master instructs the seeker to rise and escorts him to the west end of the carpet.

Chaplain: The word of the Lord came to Solomon: "As for this temple you are building, if you follow my decrees, observe my laws and keep all my commands and obey them, I will fulfill through you the promise I gave to David your father." (1 Kings 6:11-12).

The chaplain takes the letter "S" from his table, holds it up and says in the direction of the Seeker(s):

Chaplain: SOLOMON.

The chaplain then places the letter "S" on the Carpet and returns to his seat.

Chaplain: And I will live among the Israelites and will not abandon my people, Israel. So, Solomon built the temple and completed it. He lined its interior walls with cedar boards, paneling them from the floor of the temple to the ceiling, and covered the floor of the temple with planks of juniper. He partitioned off twenty cubits at the rear of the temple with cedar boards from floor to ceiling to form within the temple an inner sanctuary, the Most Holy Place. The main hall in front of this room was forty cubits long. The inside of the temple was cedar, carved with gourds and open flowers. Everything was cedar; no stone was to be seen.

He prepared the inner sanctuary within the temple to set the ark of the covenant of the Lord there. The inner sanctuary was twenty cubits long, twenty wide and twenty high. He overlaid the inside with pure gold, and he also overlaid the altar of cedar. Solomon covered the inside of the temple with pure gold, and he extended gold chains across the front of the inner sanctuary, which was overlaid with gold, so he overlaid the whole interior with gold. He also overlaid with gold the altar that belonged to the inner sanctuary.

For the inner sanctuary he made a pair of cherubim out of olive wood, each ten cubits high. One wing of the first cherub was five cubits long, and the other wing five cubits—ten cubits from wing tip to wing tip. The second cherub also measured ten cubits, for the two cherubim were identical in size and shape. The height of each cherub was ten cubits. He placed the cherubim inside the innermost room of the temple, with their wings spread out. The wing of one cherub touched one wall, while the wing of the other touched the other wall, and their wings touched each other in the middle of the room. He overlaid the cherubim with gold.

On the walls all around the temple, in both the inner and outer rooms, he carved cherubim, palm trees and open flowers. He also covered the floors of both the inner and outer rooms of the temple with gold. For the entrance to the inner sanctuary, he made doors out of olive wood that were one fifth of the width of the sanctuary. And on the two olive-wood doors he carved cherubim, palm trees and open flowers, and overlaid the cherubim and palm trees with hammered gold. In the same way, for the entrance to the main hall he made doorframes out of olive wood that were one fourth of the width of the hall. He also made two doors out of juniper wood, each having two leaves that turned in sockets.

He carved cherubim, palm trees and open flowers on them and overlaid them with gold hammered evenly over the carvings. And he built the inner courtyard of three courses of dressed stone and one course of trimmed cedar beams. The foundation of the temple of the Lord was laid in the fourth year, in the month of Ziv (zeev). In the eleventh year in the month of Bul (bool), the eighth month, the temple was finished in all its details according to its specifications. He had spent seven years building it. (1 Kings 6:13-38)

§37 Free Gardener-Master: Gauntlets (cuffs)

The Instruction Master leads the seeker(s) to the WM:

WM: The temple was completed with master craftsmanship, as was the royal garden of the temple. Therefore, from now on, wear these gauntlets as a sign of metaphorical gardening.

The WM hands the seeker first the left and then the right gauntlet, which the seeker must put on himself in the same order. If there are several Admissions, this section is done with all seekers together and at the same time.

The WM raises the compass from the master's table and addresses the seeker:

WM: The compass is the tool of the Supreme Gardener of the Universe, who conceives, develops, shapes, and creates the world with a stroke of the compass. The compass is a symbol of faith. Take it, touch your apron with it, then place it upon the Bible.

The WM raises the square from the master's table and addresses the seeker:

WM: The square is the tool by which the Supreme Gardener of the Universe measures and judges the actions of man. The square is a symbol of hope. Take it, touch your sash with it, then place it upon the Bible.

The WM raises the pruning knife from the master's table and addresses the seeker:

WM: The pruning knife is the gardener's simplest tool and the Free Gardener's highest ornament. With it, the Supreme Gardener of the Universe intervenes in Creation. The pruning knife is a symbol of love. Take it, touch your left cuff with it, then place it upon the Bible.

Immediately afterwards, the compass, the square and the pruning knife are to be placed to the left of the Bible as before. The WM can say a few free words about this, e.g. "the square should be placed behind the Compass and stands for Free Gardening in general. The square above the compass and the blade on the right side stands for the Master Degree, the blade on the left side for the Master Lodge. The change of the position of the square is made consciously because the square stands for the human actions, which a Master Free Gardener must consciously align his actions in accordance with his vows. The compass, square and pruning knife must be reordered on the left before the chain is formed.

WM: Let us come forward and form the chain.

The WM and the Instruction Master step with ALL into the chain. The WM forms the beginning of the chain, stepping in front of his table, and the EM forms the end of the chain in the west, stepping in front of his table. The WM addresses the members:

WM: Dear brothers and sisters, I present to you our new Master Gardener(s). --- We stand here united, side-by-side as a closed chain, for we have all pledged as Master Gardeners to give instructions and obey them ourselves, BUT always in accordance with the customs of the Order! To support, encourage and protect our brothers and sisters whenever possible. To strive earnestly, sincerely, and zealously, for the Friendship of every member. That is the way of Free Gardening!

[short pause.]

Return now to your seats, BUT never forget the true meaning of this moment!

[Short pause, music if possible]

§38 Free Gardener-Master: Sign, Token, Word and Motto

The Worthy Master instructs the seeker in the presence of the Instruction Master.

WM: I will now instruct you in the Sign, Token, Word and Motto of this degree.

The Sign [*The WM makes the sign*]. The Master Gardener sign is --- -- ---- made ---- -- ----
at ---- ----, --- -- necessarily ---- -- ----.

The Token is given by ---- ---- ---- and the ---- ---- (near --- ----) of the ---- ----.

The WM demonstrates with the seeker. (If there are several Admissions, the token is given to each one).

The Word is: ----, and is given in the following manner:

The WM together with the IM.

WM: Give me the word

IM: Give me the first letter.

WM: -

IM: -

WM: -

IM: -

WM: -

IM: -

WM: --

IM: --

WM: --

WM and IM [*say together*]: ----

WM: The motto is ---- (1 Kings 6:12)

The Instruction Master brings the seeker before the EM. The WM takes his seat.

IM: Emissary Master, I present to you Brother/Sister [First and Last Name].

EM: Brother/sister [First and Last Name], do you have something to give me?

Seeker: Yes. The Sign.

EM: Give me the sign.

Seeker makes the sign.

Secretary: It is given ---- --- ----- and --- ----- ----- "–", meaning -----, and the ----- s----- ----- stands for the ----- of -----: ----, ---- and -----.

EM: Do you have anything else to give with me?

Seeker: Yes. The token.

EM: Give me the token.

EM approaches the seeker to receive the token then returns to his station.

Secretary: This alludes to the f--- --- ----- ----- between all like-minded Free Gardeners; from the very first to the very last.

EM: Do you have anything else to give me?

Seeker: Yes. The word.

EM: Give me the word.

Seeker: Give me the first letter:

EM: -

Seeker: -

EM: -

Seeker: -

EM: -

Seeker: -

EM: --

Seeker: --

EM: --

EM and Seeker [say together]: -----

Secretary: It is the name of the ----- ----- of the ----- ----- of -----.

EM: Do you have anything else to give me?

Seeker: Yes. The motto.

EM: Give me the motto.

Seeker: ----.

Secretary: It means: -- -----!

The Instruction Master leads the seeker(s) before the Master's Table in the East.

WM: Brother/sister [First and Last Name], we welcome you to our garden and to the rank of Master Gardener. I offer you heartfelt congratulations, for your seedling has begun to sprout in the metaphorical garden. Our Order is like small plots of land in a garden or field—each well suited for cultivating not only trees but individuals. These metaphorical plots of land have been chosen by the heart to foster growth within our Order. Our purpose is to shield one another from suffering and to tend to those whose spirits are torn with pain. It falls to each of us to offer the soothing balm of consolation, to ease and heal the wounds, sorrows, and burdens we encounter.

When our virtues are cherished, new buds appear, branches take form, and eternal life begins wherever the light touches. From this, the most beautiful blossoms, the ripest fruits, and the brightest rays revive the spirit, giving it strength even in the darkest times.

A garden mirrors a living, thinking being—its desires and tendencies, its passions and prejudices, reflect the weeds and invasive plants that always find a way in. Just as no garden is ever entirely free from weeds and pests, so too can the human heart never be fully shielded from harmful emotions.

It is the role of a skilled gardener to remove whatever leaches, takes root, and stunts the growth of worthy plants. Likewise, it is the duty of a true Free Gardener to guard the heart—clearing away harmful habits, misguided passions, and unchecked prejudices that would otherwise choke the seed of virtue and leave the soul a barren field.

The Instruction Master places the seeker in the southwest of the lodge.

§39 Free Gardener-Master: Reading of the story

WM: Brother Secretary, read "The History of the Royal House of David."

The secretary reads §41.

After a short break, the WM and the IM demonstrate the Master Free Gardner's Catechism, §40.

§40 Free Gardener-Master: Catechism

WM: For what purpose have we gathered?

EM: For pleasure, aid, and instruction.

WM: What aims guide the path of every Free Gardener?

EM: The comfort of a clear conscience, the faithful fulfilment of their duties, and the pleasure of seeing each member happy.

WM: How do members benefit from the Order?

EM: By contributing to the health and strength of fellow members, so that they may better cope with life's challenges and misfortunes.

WM: Why is the Lodge compared to a garden?

EM: Just as a garden has flowers, plants, shrubs and trees of different species, characteristics and merits, so does the Lodge welcome people of different opinions, backgrounds and abilities; and as a garden requires the hand of the cultivator to remove the harmful weeds and grow the more useful plants with delicate care, so does the spirit of man need guidance in education and philosophy - to eliminate envy, arrogance and laziness, which makes men useless.

That is why we call ourselves Free Gardeners; but we must always remember that it is not the title, but the honorable principles that should adorn our conduct that makes us true Free Gardener.

WM: My esteemed brothers and sisters, I will now further induct you into our Order as Master Gardener. This third degree is the most illustrious but also the most unifying of all degrees. We call it the Degree of ----- . For this reason, the Hebrew word ---- was chosen as its motto, which means "-- ----", and refers to the Word of this degree, ----- . (1 Kings 6:12). The Word and Motto of this degree together means: "----- -----!".

EM: After the temple and its garden were completed, the ark of the covenant was brought into the temple. King Solomon knelt before the altar of the Lord, raised his hands to heaven, and prayed—just as the Free Gardeners continue to do today.

When he had finished his prayer, Solomon rose from where he had knelt and again lifted his hands to heaven (1 Kings 8:54). This is why Free Gardeners kneel when taking a solemn vow and stand with raised hands when they pray.

In the tradition of our brotherhood, King Solomon is also said to have planted an olive grove near the brook Kidron. For this reason, Free Gardening is counted among the royal arts, and King Solomon is honored as one of its original practitioners—the first Free Gardener from the royal house of David.

WM: The three tools you see on the upper flap of your apron are the compass, the square and the pruning knife. They are considered the general tools of our Order. The compass is the tool of God the Creator, who conceives, develops, shapes and creates the world with the stroke of a compass. The square is the tool by which he directs human actions with genuine love (1st virtue), divine wisdom (2nd virtue), true harmony (3rd virtue), and eternal truth (4th virtue). With the gardener's simplest tool, and the Free Gardener's highest ornament the pruning knife - God, the Supreme Gardener of the Universe, intervenes in creation. With it, he influences the development of nature and the evolution of man, by cutting away the vices and engrafting virtues.

EM: The four sections on the apron as well as the four symbols in each section alludes to the four elements and the Four Kingdoms of Nature that you learned in the Apprentice Degree and the Journeyman Degree, but also to the divine, spiritual, mental, and physical worlds. In each world, the four elements are contained but only one of them is dominate over the other three.

WM: Dear brother/sister, you have now completed the cycle of our teachings, but the noble and profound teachings that our Order holds are far from being complete.

From time to time, your attention has been drawn to various symbols—each offering guidance on how to conduct oneself as a Free Gardener. The All-Seeing Eye reminds us of God's omnipresence, observing not only our actions but also our innermost thoughts. It is not enough for a Free Gardener to appear faultless before others; he must be able to stand blameless before the Divine Judge at any moment. Thus, he must be virtuous in deeds and words— as well as thoughts and feelings.

The Bible, or the open book, signifies the moral teachings of Holy Scripture, ever present as a compass in daily life. It also represents the great book of nature, open for all to explore. A Free Gardener must cultivate his knowledge of nature's mysteries, like the radiant hues of lilies and the quiet wisdom of trees. In every blossom lies the grammar of creation, in each flower the rhetoric of life, in each tree the dialectic of the soul. Every bud reflects eternal arithmetic; every flower carries sacred geometry; every leaf holds the music of the world; and in each blade of grass, the workings of celestial astronomy.

The beehive and its inhabitants are a fitting symbol of industry, standing firmly against the idleness from which immorality and corruption arise. Bees are living examples of diligence and productivity—but it is not enough to admire them. Their lives offer a pattern we must follow. The bee gathers nectar not only for itself, but also for the hive and for humankind. So, too, does the Supreme Gardener of the Universe bestow wisdom and truth—first to the world, then to the lodge, and finally to each of us. As it is above, so it is below; in great things, as in small.

Thus, the customs of Free Gardening are meant to elevate the human spirit—to show how our principles serve God, the world, our lodge, and ourselves. Guided by the example of the beehive, our principles call us to cultivate goodness, benevolence, affection, and sincerity among all people.

The scythe is the most vivid symbol of time. It harshly cuts the fine thread of life. It teaches us that we should fully honor our time while the lamp of life is still burning, so that there will be no cause for bitter regret when our time comes to an end.

The spade reminds us that this world is but the soil of heaven. In our daily walk and self-preservation, we must cultivate those virtues that make us worthy to be chosen as sacred blooms in the celestial garden.

The rake conveys a high moral truth because it symbolizes the spirit of self-reflection.

Dear brother/sister, I trust that neither we nor you will ever have cause to regret joining the Free Gardeners, but that you will find our Order pleasant, gracious and useful, and that you will successfully apply its teachings to your daily life, because that is what it means to be a Master Gardener.

§41 Free Gardener-Master: The History of the Royal House of David

The moral teachings of our Order are based on the metaphorical and operative craft of gardening and its relation to the Old Testament. The craft of the gardener is understood therein as the oldest profession practiced by man.

God had man driven out of the garden in Eden. Adam now had to transfer his knowledge of metaphorical gardening into an operative craft to survive. He became an operative gardener. Thorns, thistles, weeds, and pests became psychological manifestations of the loss of his purity, and so he spent the rest of his existence driving them out of his garden, and out of his life.

Noah walked along the four main streams of paradise before the Flood to collect seeds, seedlings, and saplings from the garden in Eden, which had been closed to man since the exile of Adam and Eve.

Since then, all Journeyman Free Gardeners wander in search of seeds and seedlings which ultimately allude to diligence, friendship and affection.

Noah and his three sons - Shem, Japheth, and Ham – wandered around after the Flood and eventually established empires on their journeys. From Shem, his firstborn, descended the Israelites, in whose capital city was the royal garden (2 Kings 9:27 and 21:18) that King

Solomon had laid out around the temple of Jerusalem. The garden of nut trees (Pslms 6:11) that King Solomon so highly praised, was also located there.

After the completion of the temple and the temple garden, the ark of the covenant was transferred to King Solomon where he first addressed the congregation of Israel. When he had finished, he stood before the altar of the Lord, stretched out his hands toward heaven, and said, (1 Kings 8:22).

“When anyone sins against his neighbor, and is forced to take an oath, and comes *and* takes an oath before Your altar in this temple, then hear in heaven, and act, and judge Your servants, condemning the wicked, bringing his way on his head, and justifying the righteous by giving him according to his righteousness.”(1 Kings 8,31-32)

When King Solomon had finished the prayer, he stood up from where he had been kneeling and raised his hands to heaven. (1 Kings 8:54)

In the tradition of our brotherhood, King Solomon is also credited with having an olive grove planted near the brook, Kidron, because, as a faithful King, it was his duty to plant gardens; as it is written, “I made my works great, I built myself houses, and planted myself vineyards. I made myself gardens and orchards, and I planted all *kinds* of fruit trees in them. I made myself water pools from which to water the growing trees of the grove.” (Ecclesiastes 2:4-6). That is why Free Gardening is counted among the royal arts and King Solomon among the original Free Gardeners. He is considered the first Free Gardener from the royal house of David.

The place where the olive grove is located near the brook Kidron is also known as Baal-hama or ----- in the tradition of our brotherhood. A place name: Baal-hama (BAH-ahl HAH-mah) (בעלחמה) derives from the Hebrew words Baal (BAH-ahl) (בעל) and Ham (hahm) (חם) and gradually became "Lord of Ham" - the title of the descendants of the youngest son of Noah, who had mocked his father but gained knowledge by teaching through his brothers. The true meaning of the Word ----- is known only by Past-Masters.

§42 Free Gardener-Master: Closing

Before the Lodge is closed, the WM indicates to the Chaplain that he intends to close the Lodge:

WM: Brother Chaplain, I am about to close the lodge. Arrange the carpet accordingly!

The chaplain arranges the carpet, removing all items except the rake, the spade, the scythe, placing the snake above the rake, as in the apprentice degree.

When the chaplain has returned to his place, the WM says:

WM: All rise!

WM: Emissary Master, what duty now remains?

EM: To close the lodge, Worthy Master.

WM: Before the lodge is closed, let us unite in prayer.

[All give and hold the sign of reverence until the second Amen is returned.]

Chaplain: Supreme Gardener of the Universe, grant our souls rest and contentment after duty here on earth is done; that our labor may be to the glory of Thy holy name. Amen.

All: Amen.

WM: In the name of the Supreme Gardener of the Universe, I declare this lodge duly closed.

EM: And it shall remain closed until it becomes necessary to assemble once more.

WM: Emissary Master, what is our final duty before we depart?

EM: To remember the treasury, Worthy Master.

WM: Rentmaster, perform your duty.

The RM begins to collect in the south, to the west, then in the north to the east, and after the donation from the WM he puts his own donation in the bag in front of the WM and only then returns to his place and says, still standing, in the direction of the WM:

RM: Worthy Master, your order has been obeyed.

WM: Before I dismiss you, I would like to thank you for your presence here today and for your generous support. May you always carry the olive branch of peace, to show the world that love, wisdom, harmony and truth are the highest virtues of our Order. Keep in mind the motto that has been handed down to us from time immemorial: "Therefore keep watch, because you do not know the day or the hour." (Matthew 25:13).

[The chaplain solemnly closes the Bible and returns to his seat.]

The EM addresses the lodge after the chaplain has sat down, giving a short pause before speaking:

EM: So be it done!

WM: Go out into the world and plant seeds of harmony, peace and friendship among the people.

After the pronouncement of the WM and a short pause, the Gatekeeper opens the gate, goes through and remains standing in front of it outside of the Lodge. The Keyholder, on the other hand, remains standing in front of the gate inside the Lodge.

[Music]

General Notes

Free Gardening employs distinct terms to highlight its unique identity and to ensure it is not mistaken for other organizations.

God = Supreme Gardener of the Universe

Officers = Keepers

MG = Metaphorical Gardening (for a ceremonial meeting)

S. T. W. M. = sign, token, word and motto

SSr. and BBr. = sisters (Sr.) and brothers (Br.)

GB = Garden-Banquet (with or without guests and family and kids)

GE = guest evening

In Free Gardening, rituals are referred to as Ceremonies, and the Lodge is called the Garden. During Garden meetings, members are addressed as “Brother” or “Sister”; however, such titles are avoided in public settings.

The sash may be worn on official and public occasions by Journeymen, Masters, and Past Masters. A jewel is not customary in Free Gardening, though apprentices and others may wear a pin bearing the international insignia during official and public events.

In official correspondence, the titles “Brother” or “Sister” should be used, with the closing: “With floral greetings” followed by the letters P::G::H::E::. In all other communication, titles and ceremonial closings should be omitted.

Keepers should be addressed formally by their role and with the appropriate fraternal title—for example: *Brother Worthy Master*.